Collections Manager – Vertebrate Paleontology

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Field Museum www.fieldmuseum.org (http://www.fieldmuseum.org)

The Field Museum of Natural History has an immediate opening for a Collection Manager of Vertebrate Paleontology. The Field Museum's Fossil Vertebrate collections are world-class and host an incredible diversity of specimens. These include our collections of fossil mammals (~73,000 specimens including a large collection of Oligocene-Pleistocene mammals from South America), fossil fishes (~30,000 individuals ranging from the Ordovician to Pleistocene), and Paleozoic tetrapods from North America and South Africa (~3,500 specimens), among others. The vertebrate paleontology collections also include materials from the Green River Formation (mostly fish, but also including rarer mammal, bird, and reptile specimens) and a dinosaur collection that houses important holotypes and other specimens (e.g., Brachiosaurus holotype, Cryolophosaurus holotype, SUE, Archaeopteryx).

This is a full-time position in the Gantz Family Collections Center reporting to the Head of Geological Collections. The Collection Manager of Vertebrate Paleontology is responsible for managing the Museum's world-renowned fossil vertebrate collections and making them available for research, education, exhibition, and outreach. Based on best practices, the individual in this role will oversee the direct care, organization, and management of more than 100,000 specimens—some of

which are the Field Museum's most high-profile items. The successful candidate will be evaluated on their ability to care for, promote, study, build, and ensure accessibility to these collections. The Collection Manager of Vertebrate Paleontology may supervise Collections support staff in Geology and may serve as Head of Geological Collections, a rotating role through which the Museum's Geological Collections are represented on the Collections Leadership Team.

The Collection Manager will work jointly with curators to set long and short-term priorities for the vertebrate paleontology collections. They will also interact with other collections areas, research scientists, exhibition developers, education staff, and fundraisers. The Collection Manager is expected to actively seek funding to support collections care and improvement.

We are especially interested in candidates with a vision for making collections accessible through digitization and the next frontiers in natural history collections. Candidates dedicated to collections care with demonstrated leadership experience are especially encouraged to apply. As part of our commitment to transparency, we wish to note that we are not able to sponsor new H-1B visas at this time. This policy does not affect current H-1B employees.

Duties and Responsibilities:

- Establishes priorities for collection care and management in coordination with the Head of Geological Collections and relevant curatorial and research staff and develops and updates policies and procedures
- Manages the day-to-day activities for the vertebrate paleontology collections, including organizing and maintaining the specimens on display as well as those in the relevant collection ranges: the fossil fish range, the fossil amphibian and reptile range, the oversize vertebrate paleontology range, the fossil mammal range, and a range housing mounted vertebrate skeletons that are not on display
- Works with other staff to ensure collections facilities and environments are up to professional standards and, as needed, plans and executes collections reorganization and moves
- Plans, undertakes, and supervises the digitization and continuing documentation of collections including databasing, capturing digital images of scientific labels and specimens, correspondence, archives, publications, and loan records using the Museum's collection management software (EMu)
- Manages the budget for the vertebrate paleontology collection, identifies vendors, and orders supplies
- In collaboration with the paleontology curatorial team, reviews and approves research requests, including for destructive sampling

- Facilitates the use of the vertebrate paleontology collections by internal staff and outside researchers
- Manages incoming and outgoing loans for vertebrate paleontology
- Recruits, onboards, trains, supervises, and assesses staff, volunteers, interns, and students in their collections-related duties
- Oversees the addition of new collections and their incorporation into existing collections
- May serve as content adviser for relevant exhibitions and educational material
- Tracks and reports metrics for collections growth and use, including reporting to external partners such as the Bureau of Land Management for which we serve as a specimen repository
- Develops grant proposals and oversees grant projects for collections improvements and other collection-based initiatives
- Participates in museum service through museum committees and other in-house work
- As appropriate, carries out service to the field of vertebrate paleontology through participation in professional societies, such as the Society of Vertebrate Paleontology, The Society for the Preservation of Natural History Collections, The Association for Materials & Methods in Paleontology, and The Geological Society of America
- Collaborates and liaises with external partners, e.g., MorphoSource and GBIF
- Supports the Museum's public programming through outreach and science communication and promotes the Museum's mission, priorities, and fundraising goals
- Carries out vertebrate paleontology research up to a 20% commitment, if desired and approved

Work Skills, Education, and Experience:

- PhD (with an emphasis on vertebrate paleontology) with collections experience is preferred, or an equivalent combination of education and experience (e.g., Masters in Geology with at least 3 years' experience managing a vertebrate paleontology (or similar) collection)
- Excellent organizational and project management abilities, including the capacity to balance multiple priorities and multitask effectively
- Demonstrated experience working with relational databases (required)
- Supervisory experience and skills needed for directing collections personnel, including volunteers, students, and interns
- A strong background in vertebrate paleontology is required, including familiarity with other vertebrate paleontology collections and researchers

- Fluency in vertebrate taxonomy, classification, and literature
- Knowledge of best practices in collection management
- Experience in up-to-date archival storage of vertebrate specimens of all sizes
- Experience in the safe handling of vertebrate specimens of all sizes
- Familiarity with fossil preparation techniques required; experience preparing fossils highly desirable
- Knowledge of state and federal permitting requirements for collecting vertebrate fossils
- Working knowledge of international and domestic regulations for shipment of specimens, requirements for packing loans, and permits
- Experience with imaging and imaging equipment is highly desirable
- Ability to communicate in a compelling way about museum-based science and vertebrate paleontology in both written and spoken formats to a wide range of audiences
- Strong interpersonal and spoken and written communication skills, with the ability to work collaboratively and engage various stakeholders
- Previous budget development and management experience
- Experience preparing grant proposals and managing grant projects a plus

Other Information:

- Supervision Received: Receives general supervision by the Head of Geological Collections.
- Supervision Exercised: Provides general direction and task supervision to Collections support staff (e.g., Assistant Collection Manager or Collections Assistant).
- Work Hours and Shift: Typical work hours are Monday through Friday, 8:30 am–4:30 pm. Weekend and evening hours are occasionally required.
- Hybrid Eligibility: Not eligible
- Location: 1400 S. DuSable Lake Shore Dr. Chicago, IL 60605
- Union Representation: Not Applicable
- Pay Range: $64,000 – $74,000

To apply for this position please visit the museum's website: https://www.fieldmuseum.org/landing/careers (https://www.fieldmuseum.org/landing/careers)

Application review will begin December 5, 2025.

The Field Museum is an equal-opportunity employer. We are committed to providing a workplace free from discrimination, embracing diversity, and fostering

mutual respect. We value the unique perspectives each team member brings, which empowers our ability to innovate and overcome challenges.

At the Field Museum, we are dedicated to making our career website and recruitment process accessible to everyone. If you encounter any difficulty when using or accessing our online application, or if you need a reasonable accommodation for completing your application, participating in interviews, or any other part of the selection process, please reach out to us at recruitment@fieldmuseum.org.

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The Society for the Preservation of
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